

Eulogy for Dad

Dad had one piece of advice for anyone running a marathon, and he gave it on BBC Radio Kent the week before London in 2018.

"It's very easy to be sucked into running too fast too early. Try and hold back in the first couple of miles." So I'm going to try and hold back. He'd be the first to tell me I've gone off too quick.

He'd also tell you he didn't have a middle name because his family couldn't afford one at the time. He was born in 1948, the third of ten children in an Irish Catholic family on the White City estate in Belfast.

He didn't sit and talk about his childhood that much. But he did tell me about his adventures up on Cave Hill, and about getting lost along the Loughshore [LOCK-shore] one day: the relief of my grandparents when he was found safe and un-drowned, and the hiding he got after.

What I do know is that for all of his life his brothers and sisters regularly phoned him for his calm and measured advice. He was the steady one. He always was. Over the years many of them stayed with us for varying lengths of time, which was always brilliant as unlike him they were capable of making his favourite dish, his mother's vegetable soup!

He got his honours degree in Ancient and Modern History at Queen's University Belfast. After that he took a gap year doing various manual labour jobs, such as packing frozen peas at -40°C, dishwashing, steeplejacking and motorway shuttering, and he also hitch-hiked his way through Europe.

Then he did a PGCE at Bulmershe College in Reading, and that is where he met Mum, Sue.

Dad fell deeply in love with Mum. Within a few weeks of meeting her he proposed - then immediately, and drunkenly, walked into a lamppost. So she didn't take it seriously at that point. But later she proposed to him, after a walk along the Thames path to Wallingford. Mum says he had the gift of the gab and a lovely smile.

He did his teaching placement where he realised teaching kids wasn't for him. He changed track after that and became a VAT officer, then Customs and Excise, later HMRC, where he stayed for his whole career. People who worked under him and on other teams have told me the same thing over the years: everyone wanted to be on Team Reilly, both for his no-nonsense work ethic and for his great sense of humour.

My sister Mary's memories are from when we were kids: him locking eyes with us then Dad-dancing aggressively and singing Genesis, "I Can't Dance". For Mum he had a different song: Rod Stewart, "Do Ya Think I'm Sexy". And on a family holiday in France, Mary remembers Dad being a bit drunk, and kept swapping his red wine for her Vimto. She wants it known that she didn't drink the wine.

His taste in music was generally a bit better than that suggests. Mary says he was forever finding beautiful songs by little-known female singers to play her, of the slightly kooky Tori Amos variety. He even introduced her to Wet Leg.

Much earlier he'd introduced me to Simple Minds, and we went to see them several times over the years when they came to London. We went to Fairport Convention's Cropredy Festival more than once, as a family and with friends, which is why they'll be playing him out later. At the end we were playing him all his favourite artists, and he went to Pink Floyd's "Time", the track you heard as he came in. It felt very apt.

Dad and I did fall out over his true religion... which was golf. He really wanted me to love it as much as he did. I never got there. He forgave me, eventually.

I was heading off the rails as a teenager. Dad pulled me back on track, quite literally. He pointed all that energy at running - track, road, cross country - and at mountains. Every chance we got we'd drive to the other end of the country: the Lakes, Snowdonia, Scotland. Years later I took him to the Alps, which felt like the least I could do.

He came to the Harriers in his mid-forties with no particular racing record, and within a year he was running sub-forty-minute 10ks. At 49 he ran the London Marathon in three hours ten.

When the club re-formed in 1997 he became head coach, and he held that post for nearly twenty-five years. Initially he carried the training plans and the routes largely on his own, but spent two decades trying to make sure he wasn't the only coach, so that the club would outlast him. It has. The coaching team the Harriers have today is his work. He was very happy to see Yiannis take his place as head coach, and very proud of "Supreme Chief" Coach Steve Clark, who supported him in this all those years.

As well as coaching, he used his teacher training in other ways. It took him all over the world training customs officers in Europe, West Africa, the Middle East and South East Asia. In December 2003 he was in Baghdad, and missed the Harriers presentation evening. He sent an email instead, which was read out to the room: "The only running I am able to do are laps in my hotel bedroom." To be honest, I think he was more worried about getting sunburnt than he was about insurgents. He was awarded the Iraq Reconstruction Service Medal, the only medal he ever got for not running.

I joined him on the Harriers committee when I moved back to Canterbury in my late twenties, and later on the Man on the Run committee, alongside Sarah Gower.

For fourteen years he was the Race Director of Man on the Run, the one constant at every start line, and that race raised over a hundred and twenty thousand pounds for Cancer Research UK. We were invited to London as one of the best performing fundraising committees in the country and introduced to CRUK's chief scientist. Which made his own cancer diagnosis at the beginning of this year that much harder to take.

He kept running throughout his later years. After major surgery in his late sixties he was back training within the year, and back to racing form in 2016, although the operation meant he had to give up golf, which deeply saddened him. In October 2019, aged 71, he ran the Ashford 10k in exactly fifty minutes and set a club record for Vet 70 that still stands.

Because of this he stayed fit and active enough not only to help with my boys, James and Alex, as they grew up, but also to come on so many adventures with all of us. The last one was that same month, October 2019, when three generations of us went up Ben Nevis together. He instilled such a spirit of adventure in his grandchildren that both of them took their friends on similar mountain adventures across the UK as soon as they had passed their driving tests.

At the end, though, he was where he wanted to be, at home, with Mum looking after him, as she has for over fifty-two years.

Mum cared for him so attentively over the last six months... well, longer than that really, as the various illnesses he'd had over the last decade took their toll. The one thing he asked of me was to make sure she was looked after once he was gone. He also had a message for Mum and Mary, which I'm passing on now:

"Straighten your shoulders, please."

Earlier this year I told a friend how ill he was, and she said, "I know how much of a hero he is to you." I hadn't realised I talked about him like that. I'm glad she said it, because it meant I got to tell him while he could still hear it, and answer.

His heart was strong. In attitude, obviously. Anyone who knew him knows that. But physically too. Over this last year we had to tell every doctor and nurse who saw him to expect a slow, steady heart rate and not to worry about it. A runner's heart. I was holding his hand when he took his last breath, and I kept my finger on his pulse for a full two minutes afterwards, still strong and steady, before it stopped. Even then he wasn't going to be rushed.

He was my hero. Strong, steady pace, and he ran through the line with the Reilly finish.